



Hybrid Intrusion Detection System for MQTT-Based IoT Networks Using Machine Learning

Graduation Project Report

Submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of
Bachelor in Artificial Intelligence Engineering – Information Security Systems

Prepared by:

Salam abedalkader abedalkader

Supervised by:

Dr. Waseem Juneidi

Eng. Mohammad Yamen Hallak

Academic Year:
2025 – 2026

Abstract

The rapid growth of Internet of Things (IoT) networks has introduced significant security challenges, particularly due to the increasing use of lightweight protocols such as MQTT. Traditional intrusion detection systems often struggle to adapt to the dynamic and heterogeneous nature of IoT environments.

This project proposes a hybrid intrusion detection system for MQTT-based IoT networks using machine learning techniques. The system combines multiple detection approaches, including Isolation Forest for anomaly detection, Random Forest for classification, and Kullback–Leibler (KL) Divergence for measuring statistical deviation from normal behavior. These models are integrated using a stacking mechanism to produce a unified anomaly score.

To enhance adaptability, a dynamic thresholding mechanism is employed based on percentile analysis and smoothing techniques, allowing the system to adjust to real-time changes in network traffic. The system is implemented in a near real-time environment using Streamlit, where data is processed in chunks and analyzed continuously.

Experimental results demonstrate strong performance, achieving approximately 99% accuracy, with precision ranging from 0.90 to 0.97, recall between 0.93 and 0.98, and an F1 score of approximately 0.95. Additionally, the system maintains a low false positive rate, making it suitable for practical deployment in IoT environments.

The proposed approach effectively balances detection capability and reliability, demonstrating the potential of hybrid and adaptive techniques in improving IoT intrusion detection systems.

Keywords:

IoT Security, MQTT, Intrusion Detection System, Machine Learning, Hybrid Model, Anomaly Detection, Dynamic Threshold

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جدول المصطلحات

المصطلح	الاختصار	الوصف
إنترنت الأشياء	IoT	شبكة من الأجهزة الذكية المتصلة بالإنترنت، قادرة على جمع البيانات وتبادلها دون تدخل بشري مباشر.
بروتوكول MQTT	MQTT	بروتوكول مراسلة خفيف الوزن يعتمد على نموذج النشر والاشتراك، صُمم خصيصا لبيئات إنترنت الأشياء ذات الموارد المحدودة.
وسيط MQTT	Broker	الخادم المسؤول عن إدارة الاتصالات بين الناشرين (Publishers) والمشاركين (Subscribers) في بروتوكول MQTT.
النشر والاشتراك	Pub/Sub	نموذج اتصال يُرسل فيه الناشر الرسائل إلى موضوع معين، ويستقبلها جميع المشاركين في هذا الموضوع.
نظام كشف التسلل	IDS	نظام أمني يهدف إلى مراقبة حركة الشبكة أو سلوك النظام لاكتشاف الأنشطة غير الطبيعية أو غير المصرح بها.
كشف الشذوذ	Anomaly Detection	أسلوب يعتمد على اكتشاف الانحرافات عن السلوك الطبيعي بدلا من الاعتماد على أنماط هجوم معروفة مسبقا.
خوارزمية Isolation Forest	IF	خوارزمية تعلم آلي غير خاضعة للإشراف تُستخدم لعزل العينات الشاذة اعتمادا على عدد التقسيمات العشوائية.
تعلم غير خاضع للإشراف	Unsupervised Learning	نوع من التعلم الآلي لا يعتمد على بيانات موسومة، بل يستخرج الأنماط مباشرة من البيانات.
حركة مرور شبكية	Network Traffic	البيانات المتبادلة عبر الشبكة على شكل حزم أثناء الاتصال بين الأجهزة.
هجوم الإغراق	Flooding Attack	نوع من هجمات حجب الخدمة يعتمد على إرسال عدد كبير من الرسائل خلال فترة زمنية قصيرة لإرباك النظام المستهدف.
درجة الشذوذ	Anomaly Score	قيمة عددية ناتجة عن نموذج كشف الشذوذ تعبر عن مدى انحراف العينة عن السلوك الطبيعي.
العتبة	Threshold	قيمة فاصلة تُستخدم لتحويل درجة الشذوذ إلى قرار تصنيفي (طبيعي أو شاذ).
العتبة المتغيرة	Adaptive Threshold	عتبة يتم تحديثها أو تعديلها بناء على سلوك البيانات بدلا من كونها قيمة ثابتة.
المعالجة المسبقة	Data Preprocessing	مجموعة من الخطوات التي تُجرى على البيانات قبل التدريب، مثل التنظيف والتطبيع واختيار الخصائص.
استخراج الخصائص	Feature Extraction	عملية تحويل البيانات الخام إلى خصائص عددية تمثل السلوك الشبكي بشكل قابل للتحليل.
مستوى التدفق	Flow-based Analysis	أسلوب تحليل يعتمد على خصائص التدفق الشبكي بدلا من تحليل كل حزمة على حدة.
مصفوفة الالتباس	Confusion Matrix	أداة إحصائية تُستخدم لتقييم أداء نموذج التصنيف من خلال مقارنة النتائج المتوقعة بالقيم الحقيقية.

معدل الكشف	Detection Rate / Recall	مقياس يعبر عن نسبة الهجمات التي تم اكتشافها بشكل صحيح.
الإنذارات الخاطئة	False Positives	حالات يتم فيها تصنيف حركة طبيعية على أنها هجوم.
الزمن الحقيقي	Real-time	معالجة البيانات واتخاذ القرار أثناء تدفق البيانات دون تأخير زمني ملحوظ.

Introduction

The rapid expansion of Internet of Things (IoT) technologies has led to the deployment of a large number of interconnected devices across various domains, including smart homes, healthcare, and industrial systems. However, this growth has introduced significant security challenges due to the limited computational resources and weak built-in security mechanisms of IoT devices [1].

Among the commonly used communication protocols in IoT environments, the Message Queuing Telemetry Transport (MQTT) protocol has gained widespread adoption due to its lightweight nature and efficiency. Despite its advantages, MQTT lacks strong built-in security features, making it vulnerable to various types of cyber-attacks such as distributed denial-of-service (DDoS), flooding attacks, and abnormal traffic manipulation [2].

Traditional intrusion detection systems (IDS) are often not well-suited for IoT environments, as they rely on static rules or signatures and fail to adapt to the dynamic and evolving nature of network traffic. In addition, these systems may suffer from high false positive rates, which reduces their reliability in real-world applications [3].

To address these challenges, this project proposes a hybrid intrusion detection system that combines multiple machine learning techniques to improve detection performance. The system integrates Isolation Forest for anomaly detection, Random Forest for classification, and Kullback–Leibler (KL) Divergence for statistical analysis of traffic behavior. These components are combined using a stacking approach to produce a robust and adaptive detection mechanism.

Furthermore, a dynamic thresholding method is introduced to enhance the system's adaptability to changing traffic patterns. The proposed system is designed to operate in a near real-time environment, enabling continuous monitoring and detection of potential threats in MQTT-based IoT networks.

The main objective of this work is to develop an intelligent and adaptive intrusion detection system capable of achieving high detection accuracy while maintaining a low false positive rate. The system aims to provide a practical solution for securing IoT environments against emerging cyber threats.

Problem Statement

Despite the widespread adoption of IoT technologies and MQTT protocol, existing intrusion detection systems face significant challenges in effectively securing such environments. Traditional IDS approaches often rely on static rules or signatures, making them ineffective against evolving and unknown attack patterns.

Additionally, many existing machine learning-based solutions focus on either classification or anomaly detection, but fail to combine both approaches effectively. This results in limitations such as high false positive rates, lack of adaptability, and inability to detect both known and unknown threats efficiently.

Therefore, there is a need for a robust and adaptive intrusion detection system that can handle dynamic IoT environments, reduce false alarms, and improve overall detection performance.

Objectives

The main objectives of this project are as follows:

- To design a hybrid intrusion detection system for MQTT-based IoT networks.
- To combine supervised, unsupervised, and statistical techniques for improved detection performance.
- To enhance detection accuracy while minimizing the false positive rate.
- To develop a dynamic thresholding mechanism for adaptive decision-making.
- To implement a near real-time system capable of continuous monitoring and analysis.

Chapter 1 — Theoretical Background

This chapter presents the theoretical foundations relevant to the proposed intrusion detection system. It provides an overview of key concepts and technologies used in the project, including the Internet of Things (IoT), the MQTT communication protocol, intrusion detection systems (IDS), and machine learning techniques.

The purpose of this chapter is to establish a clear understanding of the underlying principles that support the design and implementation of the proposed system. In addition, it highlights the challenges associated with securing IoT environments and the limitations of traditional detection methods.

By reviewing these concepts, this chapter lays the groundwork for the proposed hybrid approach, which integrates multiple detection techniques to improve accuracy, adaptability, and overall system performance.

1.1 Internet of Things (IoT)

The Internet of Things (IoT) refers to a network of interconnected devices that communicate and exchange data over the Internet without requiring human intervention. These devices include sensors, actuators, and smart systems deployed in various domains such as healthcare, smart homes, and industrial automation. The rapid growth of IoT has enabled efficient data collection and real-time decision-making, significantly improving system performance and user experience [4].

However, IoT devices are typically resource-constrained, meaning they have limited processing power, memory, and energy capacity. This limitation makes it difficult to implement complex security mechanisms, thereby increasing the vulnerability of IoT environments to cyber threats. As a result, ensuring secure communication and anomaly detection in IoT networks has become a critical research challenge [5].

1.2 MQTT Protocol

The Message Queuing Telemetry Transport (MQTT) protocol is a lightweight messaging protocol designed for resource-constrained devices and low-bandwidth networks. It follows a publish/subscribe communication model, where clients communicate through a central broker that manages message distribution. This architecture allows efficient and scalable data exchange, making MQTT widely used in IoT applications [6].

In the MQTT model, publishers send messages to specific topics, while subscribers receive messages from topics of interest through the broker. This decoupled communication mechanism improves flexibility and reduces network overhead. However, the simplicity of MQTT also introduces security challenges, as it lacks strong built-in authentication and encryption mechanisms by default [7].

As a result, MQTT-based systems are vulnerable to various attacks, including message flooding, unauthorized access, and denial-of-service attacks. These vulnerabilities highlight the need for intelligent intrusion detection systems capable of monitoring MQTT traffic and identifying abnormal behavior patterns [8].

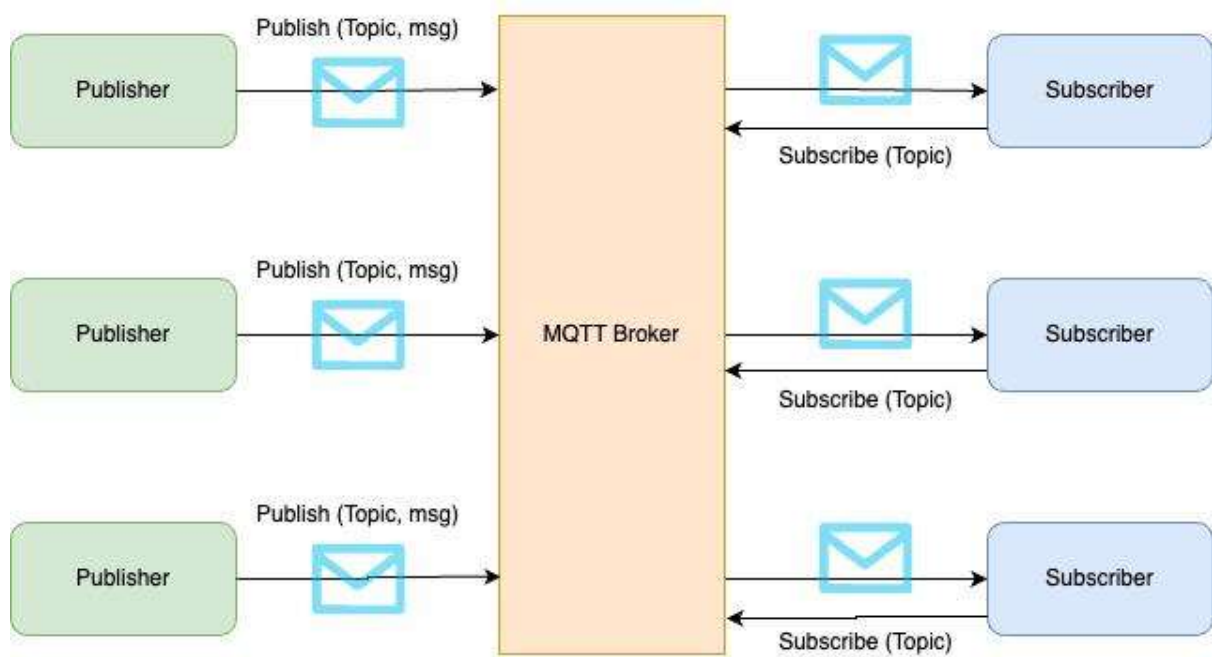


Figure 1 : MQTT publish/subscribe communication model.

As shown in Figure 1, MQTT relies on a broker-based architecture that enables efficient communication between publishers and subscribers.

1.3 Intrusion Detection Systems (IDS)

Intrusion Detection Systems (IDS) are security mechanisms designed to monitor network traffic and identify malicious activities or policy violations. IDS play a critical role in protecting network infrastructures by detecting potential attacks and generating alerts for further analysis. In IoT environments, IDS are particularly important due to the increased exposure of connected devices to cyber threats [9].

IDS can be broadly classified into two main categories: signature-based detection and anomaly-based detection. Signature-based systems rely on predefined attack patterns to identify known threats, making them effective for detecting previously observed attacks. However, they are unable to detect new or unknown attacks. On the other hand, anomaly-based systems model normal behavior and detect deviations from it, enabling the identification of novel and emerging threats [10].

Despite their advantages, traditional IDS face several limitations in IoT environments. These include high false positive rates, limited adaptability to dynamic traffic patterns, and inefficiency in handling large-scale data generated by IoT devices. These challenges highlight the need for advanced and intelligent IDS solutions that leverage machine learning techniques to improve detection accuracy and adaptability [11].

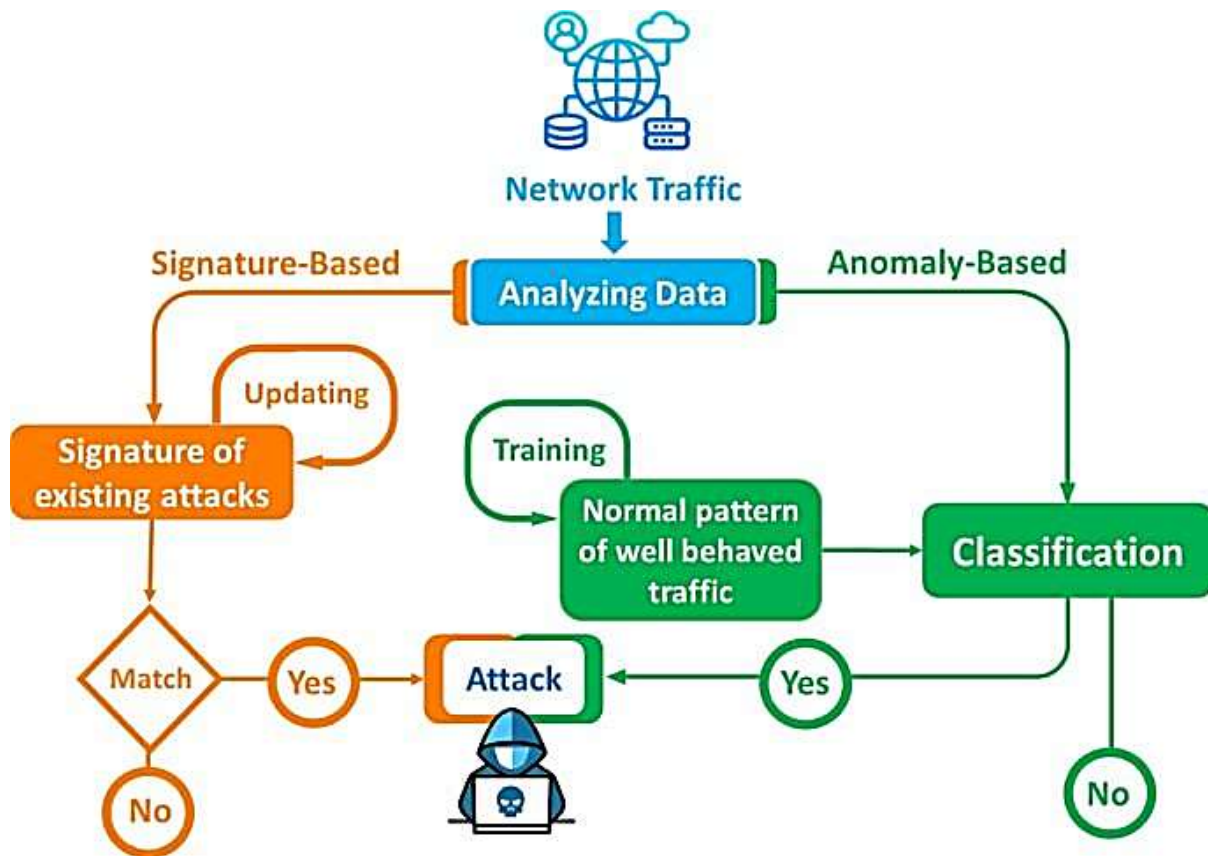


Figure 2 : Classification of intrusion detection systems.

As illustrated in Figure 2, intrusion detection systems can be categorized into signature-based and anomaly-based approaches.

1.4 Machine Learning in Intrusion Detection

Machine learning (ML) has emerged as a powerful approach for enhancing intrusion detection systems, particularly in dynamic environments such as IoT networks. Unlike traditional rule-based methods, ML-based systems can learn patterns from data and adapt to new and evolving threats. This capability makes machine learning highly suitable for detecting both known and unknown attacks in network traffic [12].

Supervised learning algorithms, such as Random Forest, are commonly used for classification tasks in IDS, where labeled data is available to distinguish between normal and malicious traffic. These models can achieve high accuracy but may struggle to generalize to unseen attack patterns. In contrast, unsupervised learning techniques, such as Isolation Forest, are used to detect anomalies by identifying data points that significantly differ from normal behavior without requiring labeled data [13].

In addition to these approaches, statistical methods such as Kullback–Leibler (KL) Divergence are used to measure the deviation between probability distributions. This allows the system to detect shifts in traffic behavior at a global level, complementing the local detection capabilities of machine learning models. By combining supervised, unsupervised, and statistical techniques, hybrid models can provide more robust and adaptive intrusion detection solutions [14].

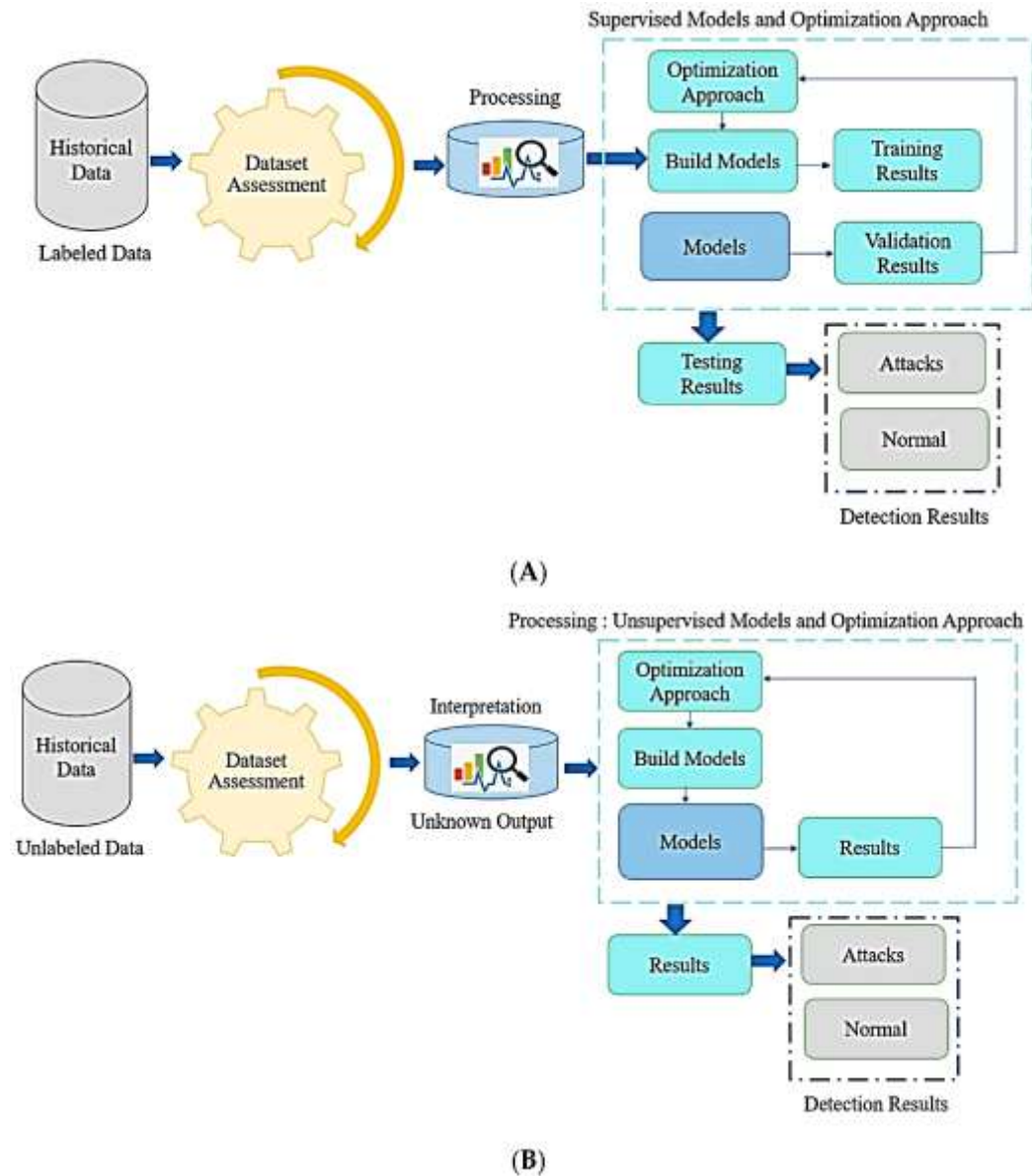


Figure 3 Supervised and Unsupervised Machine Learning Workflows for Intrusion Detection Systems.

Figure 3 illustrates the workflow of both supervised and unsupervised machine learning approaches in intrusion detection systems. In the supervised approach (A), labeled data is used

to train models, allowing the system to learn patterns associated with normal and malicious traffic. The trained models are then validated and tested to produce classification results.

In contrast, the unsupervised approach (B) operates on unlabeled data, where the system identifies anomalies by detecting deviations from normal behavior without prior knowledge of attack patterns. This method is particularly useful for discovering unknown or emerging threats.

The comparison highlights the strengths of both approaches, where supervised models provide accurate classification for known attacks, while unsupervised models enhance the ability to detect novel anomalies. This supports the motivation for adopting hybrid approaches in intrusion detection systems.

This concept is aligned with the proposed system, which combines both supervised and unsupervised techniques to improve detection performance.

Chapter 2 — Related Work

This chapter reviews recent research studies related to intrusion detection systems in IoT environments, with a particular focus on MQTT-based networks and machine learning approaches. The aim is to analyze existing solutions, identify their strengths and limitations, and highlight the research gaps that motivate the proposed work.

Several studies have explored the use of machine learning and hybrid models for detecting cyber-attacks in IoT systems. These approaches vary in terms of techniques, datasets, and evaluation methods. This chapter provides a comparative overview of these studies to position the proposed system within the current state of the art.

Table 1 presents a comparative analysis of recent intrusion detection approaches in IoT environments.

Table 1 : Comparison of Related Work in IoT Intrusion Detection Systems

Ref	Authors	Paper Title	Year	Approach	Contribution	Relation to This Work
[15]	A. Alshamrani et al.	A Survey on Advanced Persistent Threats	2023	ML-based IDS	Comprehensive overview of IDS techniques	Highlights need for adaptive IDS in dynamic environments
[16]	F. T. Liu et al.	Isolation Forest for Anomaly Detection	2024	Unsupervised	Effective anomaly detection method	Used in our system for detecting abnormal behavior
[17]	A. Khraisat et al.	Survey of Intrusion Detection Systems	2024	Hybrid IDS	Comparison between IDS types	Supports adoption of hybrid detection approach
[18]	J. Lin et al.	IoT Security and Privacy Survey	2024	Deep Learning	High detection accuracy	Shows limitations of heavy models in IoT
[19]	T. M. Cover & J. Thomas	Elements of Information Theory	2023	Statistical	KL divergence for distribution comparison	Used for detecting behavior deviation
[20]	Y. Meidan et al.	N-BaIoT: IoT Botnet Detection	2023	Deep Learning	Detects IoT botnet attacks	Shows need for

						lightweight alternatives
[21]	M. Ammar et al.	Security of IoT Frameworks	2023	ML-based	Analysis of IoT security challenges	Justifies the research problem
[22]	S. Verma et al.	Lightweight ML for IoT Security	2025	Lightweight ML	Efficient detection with low resources	Supports lightweight model design
[23]	H. Zhou et al.	Hybrid Intrusion Detection Model	2024	Hybrid	Combines anomaly + classification	Similar to our hybrid architecture
[24]	K. Singh et al.	Adaptive IDS with Dynamic Threshold	2025	Adaptive IDS	Dynamic threshold-based detection	Supports our adaptive threshold mechanism

From the comparison above, it can be observed that existing approaches either focus on accuracy, anomaly detection, or adaptability, but rarely combine all aspects together. This highlights a research gap in developing a hybrid, adaptive, and real-time intrusion detection system, which motivates the proposed work in this project.

Chapter 3 — Proposed System

This chapter presents the proposed intrusion detection system designed for MQTT-based IoT networks. The system aims to address the limitations of traditional intrusion detection approaches by combining multiple machine learning techniques with statistical analysis and adaptive decision-making.

The proposed system follows a hybrid approach that integrates supervised learning, unsupervised learning, and statistical methods to improve detection accuracy and robustness. Specifically, it utilizes Random Forest for classification, Isolation Forest for anomaly detection, and Kullback–Leibler (KL) Divergence for measuring deviations in traffic behavior.

In addition, a dynamic thresholding mechanism is introduced to adapt the detection process to changing network conditions. The system is designed to operate in a near real-time environment, where data is processed in chunks and analyzed continuously.

This chapter describes the architecture of the proposed system, the data processing pipeline, the feature engineering process, and the mathematical model used for decision-making.

3.1 System Architecture

The proposed system architecture is designed to provide an efficient and adaptive intrusion detection mechanism for MQTT-based IoT networks. The architecture consists of multiple interconnected components that work together to process incoming network traffic, extract meaningful features, and perform intelligent decision-making.

The system begins with the data acquisition module, where raw network traffic is collected and organized into manageable chunks. This is followed by the data preprocessing stage, which includes cleaning, normalization, and transformation of the data to ensure consistency and quality.

Next, the feature engineering module extracts relevant features that capture protocol behavior, temporal patterns, and interaction characteristics. These features are then passed to the hybrid detection module, which combines multiple models including Random Forest for classification, Isolation Forest for anomaly detection, and KL Divergence for statistical analysis.

The outputs of these models are integrated using a stacking mechanism to produce a final anomaly score. This score is then evaluated against a dynamic threshold that adapts to the distribution of incoming data. Based on this comparison, the system classifies traffic into normal, suspicious, or high-risk categories.

Finally, the results are visualized through an interactive dashboard that provides real-time insights into system behavior, including anomaly scores, threshold values, and detected attacks. The overall architecture of the proposed system is shown in Figure 4.

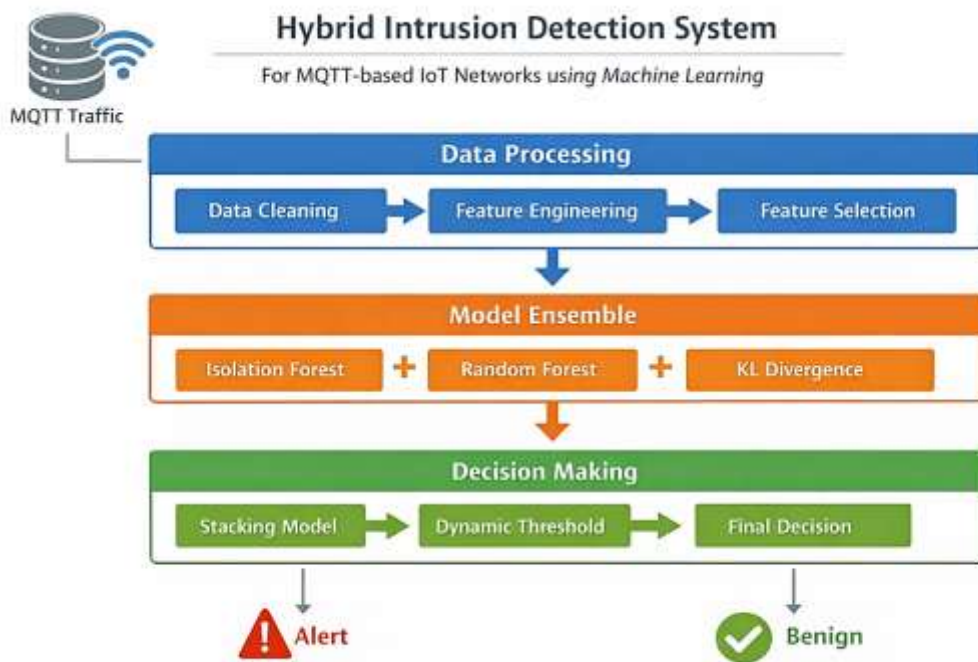


Figure 4 : Proposed hybrid intrusion detection system architecture for MQTT-based IoT networks.

Figure 4 illustrates the architecture of the proposed hybrid intrusion detection system. The system begins with MQTT traffic input, which is processed through multiple stages. In the data processing phase, raw data undergoes cleaning, feature engineering, and feature selection to extract meaningful information.

The processed data is then passed to the model ensemble layer, which combines three main components: Isolation Forest for anomaly detection, Random Forest for classification, and KL Divergence for measuring statistical deviation from normal behavior.

The outputs of these models are integrated using a stacking approach in the decision-making layer. A dynamic threshold is applied to adaptively determine whether the traffic is normal or

anomalous. Based on this process, the system produces the final decision, classifying traffic as either benign or malicious and generating alerts when necessary.

3.2 Data Processing Pipeline

The data processing pipeline is a critical component of the proposed system, responsible for preparing raw network traffic data for analysis and model input. The pipeline is designed to handle large-scale IoT traffic efficiently while maintaining data quality and consistency.

The process begins with loading the dataset, where network traffic is divided into smaller chunks to enable near real-time processing and reduce computational overhead. This chunk-based approach allows the system to process data incrementally and continuously.

Next, the data cleaning stage is applied to remove missing values, inconsistent entries, and irrelevant information. This step ensures that the dataset is reliable and suitable for further processing.

After cleaning, feature engineering is performed to extract meaningful characteristics from the raw data. These features include protocol-specific attributes (such as MQTT header flags and message length), temporal features (such as time differences between packets), and behavioral features (such as message rate and frequency patterns).

Following feature extraction, feature selection techniques are applied to identify the most relevant features and eliminate redundant or less informative ones. This helps improve model performance and reduces computational complexity.

Overall, the data processing pipeline transforms raw IoT traffic into structured and informative data that can be effectively used by the hybrid detection model.

3.3 Feature Engineering

Feature engineering is a crucial step in the proposed system, as it transforms raw network traffic data into meaningful representations that can be effectively used for intrusion detection. The goal of this process is to capture patterns related to protocol behavior, temporal dynamics, and traffic characteristics.

In this work, a set of features was carefully selected to represent different aspects of MQTT-based IoT traffic. These features include protocol-level attributes such as MQTT header flags and message identifiers, traffic-based features such as packet size and message rate, and temporal features such as time differences between packets. In addition, behavioral features were derived to capture interaction patterns and frequency distributions within the traffic.

The selection of features was not arbitrary but based on three main factors: domain knowledge of MQTT protocol behavior, insights from related work, and experimental evaluation. Feature selection techniques were applied to identify the most relevant subset of features and eliminate redundant or less informative ones. Experimental results showed that selecting 12 features provided better performance compared to using the full feature set, improving model generalization and reducing noise.

The selected features used in this work are listed in Table 2.

Table 2 presents the mapping between the selected features and the supporting literature.

Table 2 Mapping of Selected Features to Supporting Research

Feature	Description	Supported by Literature	Purpose in This Work
mqtt.hdrflags	MQTT header flags	Vaccari et al., 2023	Identifies abnormal MQTT control behavior
mqtt.len	MQTT message length	Vaccari et al., 2023	Detects unusual message sizes
tcp.len	TCP packet size	Meidan et al., 2023	Captures traffic anomalies
mqtt.msgid	MQTT message identifier	Vaccari et al., 2023	Tracks message patterns and irregularities
msg_rate	Message rate per time unit	Meidan et al., 2023	Detects flooding and DDoS attacks
tcp.time_delta	Time difference between packets	Hindy et al., 2023	Captures temporal anomalies
qos_freq	QoS frequency distribution	Vaccari et al., 2023	Identifies abnormal QoS usage

msgtype_freq	Message type frequency	Vaccari et al., 2023	Detects abnormal protocol behavior
fast_packet	High-speed packet indicator	Meidan et al., 2023	Detects rapid traffic bursts
tcp.flags	TCP flags behavior	Hindy et al., 2023	Identifies suspicious TCP patterns
rolling_msgtype_mean	Moving average of message types	Ferrag et al., 2024	Captures behavioral trends
dup_msg_interaction	Duplicate message interaction	Vaccari et al., 2023	Detects replay or abnormal interactions

As shown in Table 2, the selected features are supported by previous research and are designed to capture different dimensions of network behavior, including protocol activity, traffic intensity, and temporal patterns. This combination of features enhances the ability of the system to detect both known and unknown attacks effectively.

3.4 Hybrid Detection Model

The proposed intrusion detection system is based on a hybrid model that integrates multiple detection techniques to improve accuracy, robustness, and adaptability. Instead of relying on a single model, the system combines supervised learning, unsupervised learning, and statistical analysis to capture different aspects of network behavior.

The hybrid model consists of three main components: Random Forest (RF), Isolation Forest (IF), and Kullback–Leibler (KL) Divergence. Each component plays a distinct role in the detection process.

Random Forest is used as a supervised learning model to classify network traffic into normal or malicious categories based on labeled data. It is effective in capturing complex patterns and relationships between features, providing high classification accuracy for known attack types.

Isolation Forest is an unsupervised anomaly detection algorithm that identifies abnormal data points by isolating them in a feature space. Unlike supervised models, it does not require labeled data and is particularly useful for detecting unknown or novel attacks.

KL Divergence is employed as a statistical measure to quantify the difference between the current traffic distribution and a reference distribution representing normal behavior. This allows the system to detect global deviations in network behavior that may not be captured by individual models.

The outputs of these three components are combined using a stacking approach. Each model produces a score representing the likelihood of anomalous behavior. These scores are then aggregated to form a final decision score, which reflects the overall risk level associated with the input data.

This hybrid approach enhances detection performance by leveraging the strengths of each method. Random Forest improves classification accuracy, Isolation Forest enhances anomaly detection, and KL Divergence captures distribution-level changes. Together, they provide a comprehensive and adaptive intrusion detection mechanism suitable for dynamic IoT environments.

The integration of multiple detection techniques reduces the limitations associated with individual models. While supervised models may fail to detect unseen attacks, and unsupervised models may produce higher false positives, the hybrid approach balances these trade-offs to achieve more reliable and stable detection results.

3.5 Dynamic Threshold

A dynamic thresholding mechanism is adopted in the proposed system to improve adaptability and stability in intrusion detection. Unlike traditional static thresholds, which rely on fixed values, the dynamic threshold adjusts automatically based on the distribution of the incoming data.

The threshold is computed using a percentile-based approach applied to the anomaly scores generated by the hybrid model. Specifically, a target detection rate is estimated from the current data distribution, and the threshold is set accordingly using percentile analysis. This allows the system to adapt to varying traffic conditions in IoT environments.

In addition, a smoothing technique is applied to prevent abrupt changes in the threshold value. This ensures that the system remains stable over time and avoids excessive fluctuations that could lead to inconsistent detection behavior.

The use of dynamic thresholding is particularly important in IoT networks, where traffic patterns are highly variable and unpredictable. A fixed threshold may either miss attacks or generate excessive false positives, whereas an adaptive threshold provides a balanced and responsive detection mechanism.

The threshold is continuously updated for each incoming data chunk, enabling near real-time adaptation to changing network behavior. This approach improves both detection accuracy and system reliability.

Let $S = \{s_1, s_2, \dots, s_n\}$ represent the anomaly scores produced by the hybrid model. The dynamic threshold T is computed as:

$$T = \text{Percentile}(S, 100 \times (1 - r))$$

where r represents the target detection rate derived from the current data distribution. This formulation allows the threshold to adapt automatically based on the statistical properties of the scores.

The use of percentile-based thresholding is supported by previous research in anomaly detection, where adaptive thresholds are commonly used to handle non-stationary data distributions. Studies have shown that fixed thresholds are not suitable for dynamic environments such as IoT networks, as they fail to adjust to changing traffic patterns. Instead, adaptive thresholding methods improve detection robustness and reduce false positive rates.

Furthermore, smoothing techniques are widely used in time-series analysis and real-time systems to stabilize decision boundaries and prevent noisy fluctuations. This combination of adaptive thresholding and smoothing provides a reliable mechanism for intrusion detection in continuously evolving network environments.[35-39]

The behavior of the dynamic threshold over time is illustrated in Figure 5.

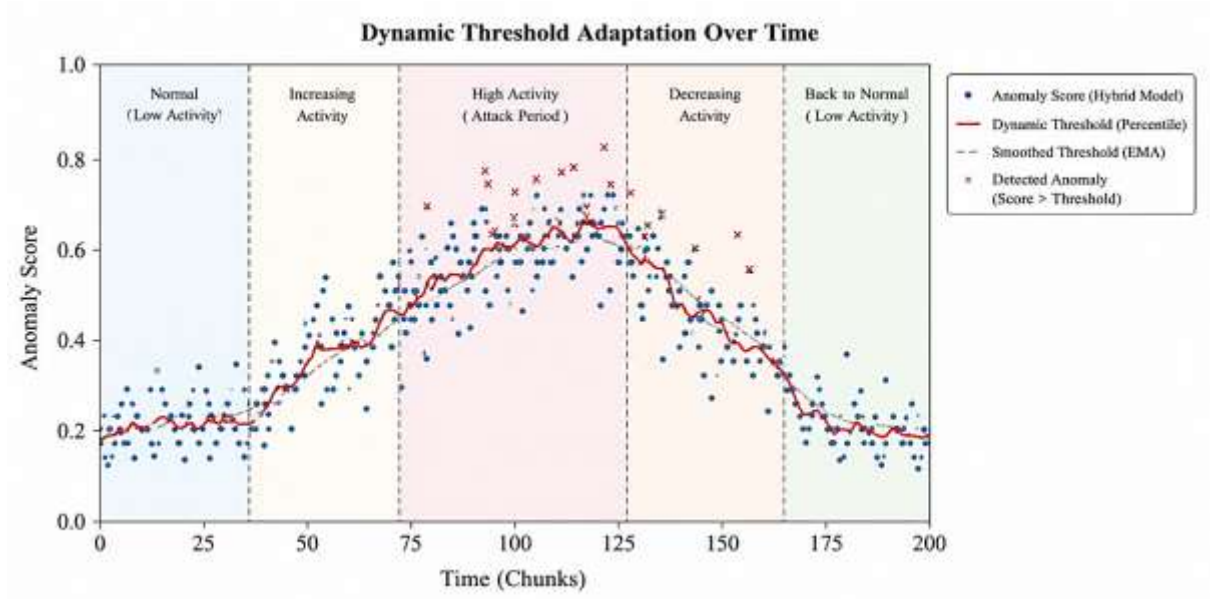


Figure 5: Dynamic threshold adaptation over time based on anomaly score distribution.

Figure 5 shows the variation of anomaly scores over time along with the dynamically computed threshold. The threshold adapts to changes in the distribution of the scores, increasing during periods of high activity and decreasing when the traffic returns to normal. This adaptive behavior allows the system to maintain stable and reliable detection performance in dynamic IoT environments.

3.6 Mathematical Model

The proposed system employs a stacking-based mathematical model to combine the outputs of multiple detection techniques into a unified decision. Instead of using manually assigned weights, the system relies on a meta-model that learns how to optimally integrate the outputs of the individual models.

Let $RF(x)$, $IF(x)$, and $KL(x)$ denote the outputs of the Random Forest, Isolation Forest, and KL Divergence components, respectively, for a given input sample x . These outputs represent different perspectives of the data, including classification probability, anomaly score, and statistical deviation.

The outputs of these models are combined using a stacking approach, where a meta-model M is trained to map these outputs into a final anomaly score $S(x)$, defined as:

1) Random Forest (RF)

$$RF(x) = (1 / N) * \sum_{i=1}^N T_i(x)$$

Random Forest is an ensemble learning method that combines the outputs of multiple decision trees. The final prediction is computed as the average of the individual tree outputs.

2) Isolation Forest (IF)

$$s(x, n) = 2^{\{-E(h(x)) / c(n)\}}$$

Isolation Forest assigns an anomaly score based on the average path length required to isolate a data point.

3) KL Divergence

$$D_{\{KL\}}(P \parallel Q) = \sum P(x) \log(P(x) / Q(x))$$

KL Divergence measures the difference between two probability distributions, representing the deviation of current behavior from normal behavior.

4) Stacking Model

$$S(x) = M(RF(x), IF(x), KL(x))$$

where M is the meta-model that learns the optimal combination of the input features during training.

The final anomaly score $S(x)$ is then compared with a dynamic threshold T to determine the classification outcome:

If $S(x) > T \rightarrow$ Anomalous (Attack)

If $S(x) \leq T \rightarrow$ Normal (Benign)

This formulation allows the system to automatically learn the best way to combine multiple detection signals, improving accuracy and adaptability. The stacking model enhances the system's ability to detect both known and unknown attacks by leveraging the complementary strengths of the individual components.

The use of a stacking model eliminates the need for manually tuning weights and enables data-driven decision-making. The meta-model learns complex relationships between the outputs of the individual models, allowing more accurate and robust detection compared to simple aggregation methods.

3.7 Real-Time Implementation

The proposed system is implemented in a near real-time environment to continuously monitor and analyze MQTT network traffic. The implementation is designed to process incoming data streams efficiently while maintaining low latency and high detection performance.

The system operates using a chunk-based processing approach, where incoming data is divided into smaller segments. Each chunk is processed independently through the data pipeline, including preprocessing, feature extraction, and hybrid model evaluation. This approach allows the system to handle continuous data streams without overloading computational resources.

The detection process is performed sequentially for each chunk. First, anomaly scores are generated using the hybrid model, which combines Random Forest, Isolation Forest, and KL Divergence. Then, the dynamic threshold is computed based on the distribution of the scores within the current chunk. Finally, each data point is classified as normal or anomalous based on its score relative to the threshold.

The system is integrated with a Streamlit-based interface that provides real-time visualization of detection results. The interface displays anomaly scores, threshold values, detected attacks, and overall system status. This allows users to monitor network behavior and respond to potential threats effectively.

The use of real-time processing and interactive visualization enhances the practical applicability of the system in IoT environments, where continuous monitoring and rapid response are essential.

The chunk-based processing strategy improves system scalability and enables adaptive analysis of streaming data. It also allows the dynamic threshold to be updated continuously, ensuring that the detection mechanism remains responsive to changes in network behavior.

Chapter 4 — Implementation and Experimental Setup

4.1 Dataset Description

This section describes the dataset used to train and evaluate the proposed intrusion detection system. The experiments in this work are conducted using the MQTTset dataset, which is specifically designed for intrusion detection in MQTT-based IoT environments.

The MQTTset dataset contains network traffic data collected from IoT systems using the MQTT protocol. It includes both legitimate traffic and various types of cyber-attacks, such as denial-of-service (DoS), brute-force attacks, malformed packets, slow-rate attacks, and flooding attacks. The dataset provides labeled instances that enable both supervised and unsupervised learning approaches.

The dataset used in this work consists of a total of 2,097,150 samples. These samples are equally divided into training and testing subsets, where each subset contains 1,048,575 samples.

In terms of class distribution, the training dataset includes 1,034,228 legitimate samples and 14,347 attack samples. Similarly, the testing dataset contains 1,034,103 legitimate samples and 14,472 attack samples.

The dataset is highly imbalanced, with attack samples representing approximately 1.08% of the training data and 1.09% of the testing data. This imbalance reflects realistic IoT network conditions, where malicious traffic is relatively rare compared to normal behavior.

The dataset originally contains multiple features related to network traffic and MQTT protocol behavior. In this work, a subset of 12 relevant features is selected based on feature engineering and selection techniques to improve detection performance and reduce computational complexity.

The use of the MQTTset dataset provides a realistic and representative environment for evaluating the proposed intrusion detection system, as it captures real-world IoT communication patterns and attack scenarios.

The distribution of the dataset used in this work is summarized in Table 3.

Table 3: Dataset Distribution of MQTTset

Dataset	Total Samples	Normal Samples	Attack Samples	Attack Percentage
Training Set	1,048,575	1,034,228	14,347	1.08%
Testing Set	1,048,575	1,034,103	14,472	1.09%
Total	2,097,150	2,068,331	28,819	1.37%

Table 3 presents the distribution of normal and attack samples in the MQTTset dataset.

The table shows that the dataset is highly imbalanced, with attack samples representing a small fraction of the total data, which reflects real-world IoT network conditions.

4.2 Implementation Environment

This section describes the implementation environment and tools used to develop and evaluate the proposed intrusion detection system.

The system is implemented using Python as the main programming language due to its extensive support for data analysis and machine learning applications. Several libraries and frameworks are utilized to support different components of the system.

Pandas and NumPy are used for data manipulation and numerical operations. Scikit-learn is used to implement machine learning models, including Random Forest, Isolation Forest, and Logistic Regression for the stacking model.

For real-time visualization and user interaction, Streamlit is used to build an interactive dashboard that displays anomaly scores, detection results, and system behavior.

The system is developed and tested on a Windows-based environment. The implementation is designed to handle large-scale data efficiently using chunk-based processing, enabling near real-time analysis.

Model persistence is achieved using the Joblib library, which allows trained models to be saved and loaded efficiently during deployment.

This combination of tools provides a flexible, scalable, and efficient environment for developing and deploying the proposed intrusion detection system.

Table 4 : Implementation Environment and Tools

Component	Tool / Technology
Programming Language	Python
Data Processing	Pandas, NumPy
Machine Learning	Scikit-learn
Visualization	Streamlit
Model Storage	Joblib
Operating System	Windows

Table 4 summarizes the implementation tools and technologies used in this work.

4.3 Data Preparation

This section describes the data preparation process applied to the MQTTset dataset before training the proposed intrusion detection system. The preparation pipeline is designed to ensure data quality, consistency, and suitability for machine learning models.

First, data cleaning is performed using a dedicated cleaning module. This includes removing duplicate records, handling missing values using statistical imputation (median for numerical features and mode for categorical features), and eliminating irrelevant textual fields related to MQTT messages. In addition, categorical features are converted into numerical representations to make them suitable for model input.

To further improve data quality, constant and low-variance features are removed, and outliers are handled using clipping techniques based on percentile thresholds. This ensures that extreme values do not negatively affect model performance.

Feature engineering is then applied to extract meaningful behavioral, temporal, and protocol-level features from the raw data. These include message frequency, packet timing, rolling statistics, and interaction-based features.

Regarding scaling, numerical normalization is selectively applied in specific components of the system. Isolation Forest and the stacking model utilize feature scaling to ensure stable anomaly score computation and effective model integration. However, Random Forest does not require scaling due to its tree-based nature.

Finally, the dataset is processed using a chunk-based strategy, allowing efficient handling of large-scale data and enabling near real-time processing in the proposed system.

4.4 Model Training

This section describes the training process of the proposed hybrid intrusion detection system. The training pipeline is designed to integrate multiple detection techniques, including supervised learning, unsupervised learning, and statistical analysis.

The training process begins with preparing the dataset after preprocessing and feature selection. The dataset is split into training and validation subsets using stratified sampling to preserve class distribution.

The Isolation Forest model is trained using only benign samples to learn the normal behavior of the system. This allows the model to detect anomalies by identifying deviations from the learned normal patterns.

Next, the KL Divergence model is fitted on the training data to establish a statistical reference distribution of normal behavior. This enables the system to measure the deviation of incoming data from expected patterns.

The Random Forest model is then trained using labeled data, where normal and attack samples are used to learn classification boundaries. The model is configured with multiple trees and balanced class weights to handle the imbalanced nature of the dataset.

After training the individual models, a stacking approach is used to combine their outputs. The outputs of Random Forest (classification probability), Isolation Forest (anomaly score), and KL Divergence (statistical score) are used as input features to train a meta-model.

A Logistic Regression model is used as the meta-model, which learns how to optimally combine the outputs of the individual models. Before training the meta-model, the input features are normalized using a StandardScaler to ensure consistent scale across inputs.

The final model is evaluated using a validation dataset, where an optimal decision threshold is determined using ROC curve analysis and the Youden Index. This threshold is then used as a reference for classification during testing and real-time deployment.

The use of a hybrid training strategy allows the system to leverage the strengths of different detection techniques. Isolation Forest enhances the detection of unknown anomalies, Random Forest improves classification of known attacks, and KL Divergence captures distribution-level changes. The stacking model integrates these outputs into a unified decision framework, improving overall detection performance and robustness.

4.5 Evaluation Setup

This section describes the evaluation methodology used to assess the performance of the proposed intrusion detection system. The evaluation is designed to measure the effectiveness of the model in detecting attacks while minimizing false positives.

Several performance metrics are used to evaluate the system, including accuracy, precision, recall, F1-score, false positive rate (FPR), and area under the ROC curve (ROC-AUC). These metrics provide a comprehensive understanding of the model's performance.

Among these metrics, the F1-score is considered the most important evaluation measure in this work. This is because the dataset is highly imbalanced, with attack samples representing a small fraction of the total data. In such cases, accuracy alone is not sufficient, as a model can achieve high accuracy by predicting the majority class. The F1-score provides a better balance between precision and recall, making it more suitable for intrusion detection tasks.

Precision measures the proportion of correctly identified attack samples among all predicted attacks, while recall measures the proportion of actual attacks that are correctly detected. The F1-score combines both metrics into a single value, providing a balanced evaluation of detection performance.

The model is evaluated on a separate test dataset that was not used during training. This ensures that the evaluation reflects the model's ability to generalize to unseen data.

In addition, ROC curve analysis is used to evaluate the trade-off between true positive rate and false positive rate. The optimal decision threshold is determined using the Youden Index, which maximizes the difference between true positive rate and false positive rate.

This evaluation setup ensures that the proposed system is assessed in a realistic and reliable manner, taking into account both detection capability and false alarm rates.

4.6 System Implementation (Streamlit)

This section presents the implementation of the proposed intrusion detection system using a Streamlit-based interface for real-time monitoring and visualization.

The system is designed to simulate a real-time IoT environment by processing incoming data in chunks. Each data chunk is passed through the full processing pipeline, including data cleaning, feature engineering, feature selection, and hybrid model evaluation.

The implementation integrates previously trained models, including Random Forest, Isolation Forest, KL Divergence, and the stacking meta-model. These models are loaded using the Joblib library and applied directly to incoming data without retraining.

For each data chunk, anomaly scores are computed using the hybrid model. These scores are then normalized and evaluated using a dynamic threshold, which is updated continuously based on the distribution of the current data.

The Streamlit interface provides real-time visualization of the system's behavior. It displays anomaly scores, classification results, threshold values, and alert indicators. The interface also includes graphical representations such as scatter plots for traffic classification and histograms for score distribution.

In addition, key performance indicators (KPIs) are displayed, including detection rate, number of alerts, and current threshold value. These metrics provide a quick overview of system status and allow users to assess the level of threat in the network.

The system continuously updates the display in a loop, simulating streaming data and enabling near real-time intrusion detection. This implementation demonstrates the practical applicability of the proposed system in monitoring IoT network traffic and detecting potential attacks dynamically.

The dynamic threshold is computed using a percentile-based approach and updated using an exponential moving average (EMA) to ensure stability over time. This allows the system to adapt to changes in traffic behavior while avoiding sudden fluctuations in detection decisions. The real-time monitoring interface of the proposed system is shown in Figure 7.

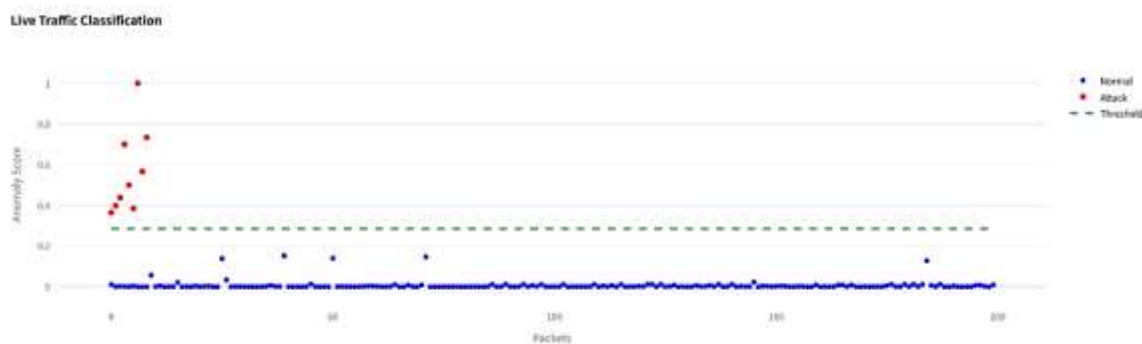


Figure 6: Real-time intrusion detection dashboard implemented using Streamlit.

Figure 7 illustrates the interactive dashboard used for real-time monitoring of network traffic. The system displays anomaly scores, detected attacks, and adaptive threshold behavior, providing immediate insights into network security status.

Chapter 5 — Results and Discussion

5.1 Introduction

This chapter presents the experimental results of the proposed intrusion detection system and provides a detailed analysis of its performance. The evaluation focuses on assessing the system's ability to accurately detect malicious activities in MQTT-based IoT networks while maintaining a low false positive rate.

The results are obtained using the test dataset described in Chapter 4, ensuring that the evaluation reflects the model's generalization capability on unseen data. Various performance metrics are used to provide a comprehensive assessment of the system, with particular emphasis on the F1-score due to the imbalanced nature of the dataset.

In addition to quantitative results, this chapter discusses the behavior of the system under different conditions, including its ability to adapt to dynamic traffic patterns and detect both known and unknown attacks.

5.2 Quantitative Results

This section presents the quantitative evaluation results of the proposed intrusion detection system on the test dataset. The results demonstrate the effectiveness of the hybrid model in detecting malicious activities in IoT network traffic.

The performance of the system is evaluated using multiple metrics, including accuracy, precision, recall, F1-score, false positive rate (FPR), and ROC-AUC. The results obtained on the test dataset are summarized in Table 5.

The system achieves an accuracy of 99.36%, indicating that the majority of samples are correctly classified. More importantly, the model achieves a precision of 90.20% and a recall of 98.14%, demonstrating its ability to detect a high proportion of attack samples while maintaining a low number of false alarms.

The F1-score reaches 94.00%, which reflects a strong balance between precision and recall. This is particularly important given the imbalanced nature of the dataset, where attack samples represent a small fraction of the total data.

The false positive rate (FPR) is only 0.57%, indicating that the system generates very few false alarms. Additionally, the ROC-AUC score of 0.9969 demonstrates excellent discrimination capability between normal and attack traffic.

Overall, these results confirm that the proposed hybrid model is highly effective in detecting intrusions in MQTT-based IoT environments while maintaining stability and reliability.

Table 5 : Performance Evaluation Results on Test Dataset

Metric	Value
Accuracy	99.36%
Precision	90.20%
Recall	98.14%
F1-score	94.00%
FPR	0.57%
ROC-AUC	0.9969
PR-AUC	0.9855

Table 5 summarizes the performance metrics of the proposed intrusion detection system on the test dataset

The results indicate that the system achieves a high recall, meaning that most attack instances are successfully detected. Although precision is slightly lower, it remains high, indicating that the number of false alarms is limited. The high F1-score confirms that the system maintains a good balance between detection capability and false positive reduction.

The low false positive rate is particularly important in real-world applications, as excessive false alarms can reduce system usability. The high ROC-AUC score further demonstrates the robustness of the model in distinguishing between normal and malicious traffic.

The strong performance of the proposed system can be attributed to the hybrid design, which combines supervised, unsupervised, and statistical detection techniques. This integration allows the system to effectively capture different types of anomalies and improve overall detection performance.

5.3 Real-Time Results Analysis

This section analyzes the real-time performance of the proposed intrusion detection system under streaming conditions. The system processes incoming data using a chunk-based approach, where each chunk contains a subset of network traffic samples.

In this work, a chunk size of 500 samples is used during real-time simulation. This value is selected to balance between computational efficiency and detection responsiveness. Smaller chunk sizes allow faster updates and quicker detection of anomalies, while larger chunk sizes provide more stable statistical estimates for threshold computation. The selected size provides an effective trade-off between these two factors.

For each chunk, the system computes anomaly scores using the hybrid model and updates the dynamic threshold based on the distribution of these scores. The threshold is adjusted using a percentile-based method combined with exponential moving average (EMA) smoothing to ensure stability over time.

The results show that the system maintains consistently high performance across different chunks. The F1-score typically ranges between approximately 0.91 and 0.95, demonstrating stable detection capability under varying traffic conditions.

The dynamic threshold adapts continuously to changes in traffic behavior. In periods of higher anomaly activity, the threshold increases to reduce false positives, while in normal conditions, it decreases to maintain sensitivity to potential attacks.

In addition, the system achieves very low false positive rates across chunks, often approaching zero in some cases. This indicates that the adaptive threshold mechanism effectively controls false alarms without significantly compromising detection performance.

Overall, the real-time evaluation demonstrates that the proposed system is capable of maintaining high detection accuracy, stability, and adaptability in dynamic IoT environments.

The observed variation in performance metrics across chunks reflects changes in traffic distribution and attack intensity. Despite these variations, the system maintains robust

performance, indicating its ability to generalize well and adapt to different operational conditions.

Table 6 : Real-Time Performance Across Chunks

Metric	Range
F1-score	0.91 – 0.95
Accuracy	0.99 – 0.995
FPR	~0.000 – 0.005
ROC-AUC	~0.96 – 0.99

Table 6 summarizes the variation of performance metrics across different data chunks.

5.4 Discussion (Strengths and Limitations)

This section provides a detailed discussion of the strengths and limitations of the proposed intrusion detection system, based on the experimental results and real-time evaluation.

One of the main strengths of the system is its hybrid architecture, which combines supervised, unsupervised, and statistical detection techniques. This allows the system to capture different types of malicious behavior, including both known and unknown attacks. The integration of Random Forest, Isolation Forest, and KL Divergence improves overall detection accuracy and robustness.

Another key advantage is the use of a stacking model, which learns how to optimally combine the outputs of different models. This data-driven approach enhances decision-making and eliminates the need for manually tuning weights.

The dynamic threshold mechanism also plays a critical role in improving system performance. By adapting to changes in traffic behavior, the system maintains a balance between detection sensitivity and false positive reduction. This is particularly important in IoT environments, where traffic patterns are highly dynamic.

In addition, the system demonstrates strong real-time performance through chunk-based processing. This enables continuous monitoring of network traffic while maintaining computational efficiency and scalability.

Despite these strengths, the system has some limitations. First, the performance depends on the quality of the selected features. If important features are missing, detection performance may be affected.

Second, the system relies on labeled data for training the supervised component, which may limit its ability to generalize to entirely new types of attacks.

Third, the choice of chunk size may influence system behavior. While the selected chunk size provides a good balance, different environments may require further tuning to achieve optimal performance.

Finally, although the system performs well under the tested conditions, further validation on different datasets and real-world deployments is required to fully assess its generalizability.

Overall, the proposed system provides a robust and adaptive solution for intrusion detection in IoT environments, with strong performance and practical applicability.

The combination of adaptive thresholding and hybrid modeling represents a key contribution of this work, as it addresses both detection accuracy and system stability in dynamic environments. This makes the proposed approach more suitable for real-world IoT applications compared to traditional static detection methods.

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